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## Colorado Field Ornithologists Sight Record Form

(Please print or type. Attach photographs and additional pages if necessary.)

**Each table cell will automatically enlarge as you type!**

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| CBRC FILE #:                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |                       |                                                                |
| RESULTS:                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |                       |                                                                |
| Species: (Common Name) Hepatic Tanager                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                       | (Scientific Name) <i>Piranga flava</i>                         |
| Date(s) of occurrence: 14 May 2004                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |                       |                                                                |
| Number of birds seen: 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | Sex: 1 male, 1 female | Plumage: adult                                                 |
| Exact location: on east side of a north trending ravine 5 miles south of Tobe, on private land adjacent to Comanche National Grassl<br>(I came in from the top of the ridge where there are no marked property boundaries)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                       |                                                                |
| County: Las Animas                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | Nearest town: Tobe    | Elevation: 6,100'                                              |
| Length of observation: intermittently for about 45 minutes                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                       | Time(s) of observation: 1130 AM to 1215 PM                     |
| Other observers who saw the bird(s) with you: none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |                       |                                                                |
| Other observers who independently saw the bird(s): probably none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |                       |                                                                |
| Light conditions (quality; direction relative to bird(s) and observers position): Bright sunlight under open canopy of ponderosa pine stand with oak brush in the understory. Birds were initially seen from eye-level in canopy (treetops seen from rim of ravine). Lat observations were from bottom of ravine looking up into trees, birds well-lighted from behind the observer. Occasionally birds we in shade of canopy branches.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                       |                                                                |
| Optical equipment used: 10x42 binoculars - Leica                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |                       |                                                                |
| Distance to bird(s) (estimated, unless otherwise noted): 25 feet at closest, up to 150 feet                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                       |                                                                |
| Was (Were) bird(s) photographed? yes                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |                       | If so, are you submitting photos? yes - attached cropped file: |
| Who took the photograph(s)? Steven Olson                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |                       |                                                                |
| Describe the general and specific habitats in which the bird(s) occurred: The area where the tanagers were seen is in the Mesa de M area. Basaltic cliffs line the upper portions of the ravine. Slopes to the ephemeral/intermittent creek are steep and rocky. Canop trees are ponderosa pine in the upper reaches of the valley, but lower in the valley one-seeded juniper becomes common. There is locally dense understory of Gambel's oak, with some Ribes spp. and mock-orange. Herbaceous ground cover includes many graminoids and a variety of forbs. Overall, ground vegetation is rather sparse. The birds spent most of their time in the middle branches of the pines.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                       |                                                                |
| Describe the bird's (birds') behaviors, particularly behaviors that were used in supporting the identification, e.g., flying, feeding, habits: The birds spent most of the time foraging in the middle branches of the ponderosa pines, occasionally going to higher branc and a few times in the upper branches of the oak brush. The birds associated with each other, but appeared next to each other only few times. The male appeared to be territorial frequently flying back and forth across the valley and also up and down the valley, returning a few minutes later to near where the female continued feeding. These flights were at about treetop level. As the femal moved from tree to tree while foraging, short flights were usually from middle level of one tree to the middle level of the next. Foraging of both birds was rather methodical, gleaning small branches and leafy branch tips.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |                       |                                                                |
| DESCRIPTION -- <b>This is the most important part of this report.</b> Include in these details the overall size and shape of the bird ar give as many plumage details as possible, even including those that you feel might not have relevance to the specific identification. Please fill out this portion even if photos are accompanying your report. The birds were small (less than Robin-sized) with shortish tails. The bodies were rounded, not to a thrush-like extent but heavier than vireos. The bill had a shape somewhat similar to that vireos, but was much heavier: relatively thick-based, arching to a sharp, abrupt tip. Most distinctive on these birds was the dark, sl gray color of the bill. The head on both birds was long-appearing. This is accentuated in the male by a slight "crest" (more of an extension of the crown) above the base of the bill. The head color in the female was greenish gray suffused with orangy yellow on the forehead and throat. The head color of the male was orangy red with gray cheeks. The eyes on both birds appeared very dark. The back of the female was yellowish olive-gray, slightly brighter on the rump. The back of the male was gray, suffused with the same orangy red as on the head, and the rump was (like the female) slightly brighter. Wings were about the same color as the back both birds, and the flight feathers appeared slightly darker. No wing bars were present. The wings extended about to the base of tail. From below, the female was yellowish gray, noticeably brighter on the throat, especially when seen in brighter conditions. The male was orangy red below, fading to gray below the wings. Legs on both birds were dark. The tail was shortish and square tipped. The color on each bird matched the rump color. |                       |                                                                |



Describe the bird's (birds') call(s) and/or song(s), if noted: Song (a few times) reminiscent of Black-headed/Rose-breasted Grosbeak but with tanager quality. A thrush-like call note heard more often.

**SIMILAR SPECIES – This is another critical part of your report.** Please discuss how you eliminated similar species from consideration:

Orioles dismissed (for female) because of bill shape. The birds seen did not have long, sharply pointed bill. Also the birds had no wingbars, and was strongly gray (not mostly yellowish).

Western Tanager has wingbars and obviously yellow below in all plumages with black (male) or blackish (female) back, lacking the grayish overtones of the birds seen. Voice burry, not as clear as the birds heard.

Scarlet Tanager male is bright scarlet red, occasionally orange, with striking black wings and tail. Female has olive green back, bright yellow below, and very dark wings and tail. The wings and tail of the birds observed were more similar to the back color.

Bill is medium gray, not dark gray to blackish. Head is evenly rounded, i.e. lacks the long headed appearance of the birds seen.

Voice burry, but with quick robin-like cadence. Call note not at all thrush-like.

Summer Tanager male uniformly deep rosy red with some pale grayish overtones. Low crest of male Summer is over crown of head making it appear tall-headed, as opposed to the long-headed appearance of the birds seen. Female Summer bright olive green above and bright orangish yellow below. Bill pale gray to whitish, not dark gray or blackish as in birds seen. Voice lacks clarity of the birds heard, but not as burry as Scarlet. Call notes typically in series, not thrush-like in quality.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly appearing species? I have seen Hepatic Tanagers in west Texas on several occasions, as well as on several occasions in southern Arizona. The habitat in those areas has a very similar structure of canopy and understory as the area near Tobe, although the species composition is very different. I "grew up" with Scarlet Tanagers in Illinois and Indiana, probably having seen and heard hundreds over the past 25-30 years. Scarlet prefers stands having denser canopies than the Tobe area. I have seen and heard nearly as many Summer Tanagers over the past 20 years in the Ohio River valley (rarely more than a dozen on a typical summer day of birding). Summer would more typically be in moister forests than the Tobe site, often near perennial streams. It would be less likely near intermittent streams, although it seems tolerant of more open canopy situations.

List books, guides, recordings, or other sources consulted and how these influenced your identification (during and after observation). Having seen and heard Hepatic Tanagers as well as the listed potential similar species on many occasions, it was not necessary to consult references for identification purposes. I did check the Sibley guide for recent distribution information to confirm that Hepatic was an unusual species for the Tobe location.

This report was made from (check one) \_\_\_ notes made during observation \_\_\_x\_\_\_ notes made after observation \_\_\_ later from memory

Date and time of written report: 14 August 2004

Reporting observer: Steven Olson

Signature: /s/ Steven Olson

Reporting observer's address: 1487 N. Challenger Ln.

City: Pueblo West

State: CO

Zip: 81007

**Send report to:**  
**Colorado Bird Records Committee**  
**Tony Leukering**  
**PO Box 660**  
**Brighton, CO 80601**





